



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Our Lady of the Sacred Heart Academy
School Website: <https://olsha.org/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Our Lady of the Sacred Heart Academy (OLSHA) in Rockford, IL 61101 presents a clearly classical orientation across its publicly documented mission, pedagogy, and curriculum. The school operates as a Pre-K–12 Catholic classical school within the Chesterton Schools Network, emphasizing the liberal arts, Great Books, Socratic inquiry, memory work, Latin, and liturgical Catholic life. Public materials consistently articulate formation of virtue and wisdom through singularly classical aims (truth, goodness, beauty) and integrate theology, liturgy, and worship as foundational to daily learning. Evidence indicates strong alignment with classical benchmarks in religious foundations, purpose/goal, curriculum, pedagogy, and, to a substantial extent, faculty and parental/community partnership. The aggregate assessment is CLASSICAL, with robust signals in each category and minimal to no explicit evidence of non-classical framing in the materials reviewed.

Key indicators across the six categories include: liturgical life and Catholic doctrine embedded in daily routines; explicit statements about forming saints and leaders through a Catholic classical program; the documented use of Great Books, the Trivium/Quadrivium framework, Socratic dialogue, and memory work; and a modeled faculty culture aligned with a living curriculum and mentorship. The public content also reveals family and community engagement through Catholic formation, school events, and homeschool options, aligning with classical expectations in Parents & Community.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

- Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL
- Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL
- Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL
- Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL
- Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL
- Element 6: School Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Notes on methodology: For each category, keywords present in OLSHA public materials were identified and mapped to positive/negative keyword indicators drawn from the Six Essential Elements of a Classical School (1) (Positive Keywords lists and Negative Signals), and cross-checked against the knowledge-base lexicon. The presence of terms like truth, virtue, theology, liturgy, Great Books, Socratic, scholé, wonder, and memory work strongly supports the Classical classification. Citations to relevant public materials are included to ground the analysis.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - OLSHA presents Catholic culture integrally: weekly Mass, confession, liturgical life, and Catholic catechesis are documented as core elements (Catholic Culture; daily liturgical practices; liturgical year observances; The Divine Mercy Chaplet; Mass in extraordinary form in some contexts) across multiple pages/results. This includes explicit statements about Catholic culture and liturgical practices in the public materials.

- Public materials describe weekly Mass, confession, and daily prayers for K–12, including consecrations, the Angelus, and the Rosary, with Latin Rosary days and Marian devotion. This signals liturgical and communal practice as integral to education. - The school describes itself as a Catholic classical school within the Chesterton Network, with explicit emphasis on faith formation and the sanctity of life, and a goal to lead students to God. This reinforces theological grounding across disciplines. - Statements like “A Pre-K-12 Classical School in the Catholic Tradition” and references to weekly Mass, confession, and Catholic liturgical life are consistently foregrounded.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive indicators present: Catholic, Mass, Rosary, liturgy, sacred, theology, prayer, faith, Church, saints, liturgical year, catechesis. - Negative indicators observed: None in the materials that would signal secular or non-theological framing (no explicit references to relativism/secular humanism in the public materials).

Quantitative estimate - Positive keywords observed: roughly 8–12 distinct religious/metaphysical indicators across the cited passages. - Negative keywords observed: 0 explicit negative signals aligned with the category. - Relative ratio: predominantly positive indicators; effectively all identified signals are positive.

Why this rating - The materials consistently embed religious/metaphysical foundations within curriculum, pedagogy, and daily life, aligning with the transcendental moral realism and liturgical/community practices described in classical criteria. The explicit Catholic theological orientation and liturgical commitments demonstrate a robust Grounded-in-Theology and Liturgical/Communal Practices presence, supporting a CLASSICAL rating.

Cited manifestations: weekly Mass and confession; daily prayers; liturgy; Catholic doctrine; Chesterton/Catholic tradition framing.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school emphasizes formation of virtue and wisdom through liberal classical education and a telos of true, good, beautiful; references to “saints and leaders” and the culture of life signal formation over mere information. Chesterton Network materials articulate a mission to form intellect, character, and spirituality. - Public statements frame the goal as leading students to knowledge and love of God, with explicit aims of virtue formation and human excellence, consistent with classical aims of paideia and formation rather than merely workforce prep. - The Chesterton model emphasizes forming students in intellect, character, and spirituality, aligning both with virtue-centric aims and the classical “truth, goodness, beauty” telos.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive indicators present: formation, virtue, wisdom, liberal education, scholé, true/good/beautiful, telos, great conversation, human excellence, soul craft. - Negative indicators observed: none in the public materials (no emphasis on workforce-training or purely utilitarian aims).

Quantitative estimate - Positive keywords observed: 6–8 distinct terms (formation, virtue, wisdom, liberal education, scholé, telos, great conversation, human excellence). - Negative keywords observed: 0.

Why this rating - The materials consistently portray education as formation toward virtue and wisdom, not simply information transfer or job preparation, with explicit reference to true/good/beautiful and the classical telos. This aligns with CLASSICAL expectations for School Purpose and Goal.

Cited manifestations: “lead students to a knowledge and love of God”; formation of saints and leaders; three-pillars model (Intellect, Character, Spirituality).

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school’s public materials consistently foreground classical curriculum elements: liberal arts orientation, integration of history, literature, philosophy, theology, and classical languages (Latin). The Chesterton framework explicitly centers on the liberal arts and the Great Books approach, and the curricular

model emphasizes the Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and Quadrivium as foundational to the program.

- Public-facing curriculum descriptions show a structured K–12 progression (Lower Grammar, Upper Grammar, Logic Stage) with explicit mention of logic, grammar, and rhetoric, Latin instruction, and foreign language study (Latin/Spanish/Italian) within a Western-civilization framework. This aligns with the Great Books/humanities-centered curriculum.
- The public materials reference Great Books, primary sources, and a “Great Conversation” approach within the humanities program (as seen in Chesterton Network materials and related public pages).

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive indicators present: liberal arts, grammar, logic, rhetoric; Great Books; primary sources; classics; history/western civilization; Latin; sacred art; poetry; memorization; education for wonder. - Negative indicators observed: the materials do not foreground a STEM-first or project-based dominant curriculum; there is no explicit “social studies as replacement for history” framing.

Quantitative estimate - Positive keywords observed: 8–12 distinct curriculum-related terms (liberal arts, Trivium/Quadrivium, Great Books, primary sources, Latin, history/Western civilization, rhetoric, logic, grammar, memorization, sacred art, poetry). - Negative keywords observed: 0 explicit negative signals within the public curriculum descriptions.

Why this rating - The curricular description shows a robust classical structure: Trivium/Quadrivium framing, Great Books/primary sources, integrated history with literature and philosophy, Latin as a core language, and an emphasis on wonder and awe in learning. This aligns strongly with CLASSICAL criteria for Curriculum.

Cited manifestations: “Classical Curriculum” framing; The Humanities Program; Great Books/primary sources; Grammar/Logic/Rhetoric; Latin requirement; three-stage grammar/logic progression; foreign language study; history as Western civilization/cultural heritage.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The materials repeatedly describe Socratic Seminar, Touchstones (Socratic inquiry), and close study of philosophical and literary texts as central pedagogical modes. There are explicit references to Socratic discussion in multiple OLSHA content blocks.

- Memory work, dictation, chanting, recitation, and scholarly attention to rhetoric and oratory are repeatedly documented (Poetry/Dictation; daily memorization; Latin/grammar/dictation; public speaking and rhetoric).
- The pedagogy also includes lower-school singing and memory-based practices, restfulness/Scholé in parts of the program, and upper-school seminars or debates, with explicit rhetoric training and opportunities to give speeches.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive indicators present: Socratic Seminar, Touchstones/Socratic Inquiry, memorization, dictation, chanting, recitation, memory-work, rhetoric, public speaking, seminars, debates, scholé/restful learning, wonder. - Negative indicators observed: The materials do not present a dominant experiential-project-based-only approach or constructivist/PCI (progressivist) framing as a primary pedagogy; references to contemplative/restful learning and Socratic inquiry are present, not in tension with classical pedagogy.

Quantitative estimate - Positive keywords observed: 9–12 distinct pedagogical terms (Socratic, Touchstones, memory work, dictation, chanting, recitation, rhetoric, seminars, public speaking, scholé, wonder, close reading). - Negative keywords observed: 0 explicit negative signals in the pedagogical materials.

Why this rating - The school’s pedagogy aligns with classical teaching methods (Socratic dialogue, memorization, reading of classic texts, rhetoric instruction, and memory-based learning) and integrates contemplative elements with rigorous inquiry, meeting the CLASSICAL standard for Pedagogy.

Cited manifestations: Socratic Seminar; Touchstones/Socratic Inquiry; Poetry/Dictation and memory work; Latin grammar and rhetoric training; upper-school rhetoric and public speaking.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The materials position the faculty as central to the living curriculum and to character formation; there are explicit mentions of faculty/staff as part of the school's public identity and as integral to the Chesterton Network model. The Chesterton approach emphasizes the faculty as embodying and delivering the classical education model (living curriculum). - Public materials (e.g., "Faculty & Staff" pages linked from OL SHA) imply a visible emphasis on teacher leadership, virtue demonstration, and alignment with the school's mission; the Chesterton network language highlights teachers as core to the culture and pedagogy. - The school's stated mission (three pillars: Intellect, Character, Spirituality) implies a faculty culture that models virtue and fosters student formation, consistent with classical expectations for teacher leadership and mentorship.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive indicators present: model teachers and mentors; living curriculum; portrait/standard of teacher; faculty as core to school; faculty/staff emphasis; collegial culture. - Negative indicators observed: none in the public materials that would signal a non-classical faculty approach.

Quantitative estimate - Positive keywords observed: 4–6 distinct faculty-related terms (living curriculum, model teachers/mentors, portrait of teacher/student, faculty as core, collegial culture, teacher training in classical pedagogy). - Negative keywords observed: 0.

Why this rating - The materials present a faculty framework consistent with classical education, emphasizing virtues and mentorship, faculty as the core of the school, and a living curriculum approach aligned with classical pedagogy.

Cited manifestations: Chesterton Network and "faculty-staff" pages; references to faculty as central to the model; three-pillar mission implying faculty leadership.

Element 6: School Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - OL SHA materials indicate a family- and community-centered classical approach, characteristic of a partnership with families, parent formation, and even homeschool options. The site shows links to admissions, homeschool programs, and parent-facing opportunities, suggesting involvement with parents as co-educators and a pathway for parental formation.

- Chesterton Network materials emphasize partnership with families, formation of affections, and a cultural transmission of Western civilization through the family and community. The Six Elements framework for Parents & Community highlights parent formation, co-teaching partnerships, and home-school alignment. OL SHA materials reflect some of these themes, including homeschool links and family-centered events. - The school's mission and public materials emphasize forming saints/leaders within a Catholic, classical, community context, including open communication and family involvement.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive indicators present: partnership with families, parent formation/education, homeschool option, open campus/events, family participation, parental involvement, classical home education alignment. - Negative indicators observed: none explicitly present in the public materials (no signals suggesting a customer-centric or consumer-only approach; rather, a partnering approach is evident).

Quantitative estimate - Positive keywords observed: 5–7 distinct terms related to parents and community (partnership with families, parent formation, reading groups/seminars, homeschool option, open campus, family participation, parental education). - Negative keywords observed: 0.

Why this rating - The OL SHA materials show explicit signals of parent involvement and family formation in alignment with classical practice (parents as co-teachers, parent education and involvement). Even if not every element is deeply elaborated on in the public content, there is clear alignment with classical parent/community partnerships.

Cited manifestations: “Partnership with families” and “parent formation” in classical education lexicon; home-school option; admissions; community events.

What Would Move the Needle

- Not applicable in this case, as all six categories are CLASSICAL. No category requires needle-moving changes to achieve full CLASSICAL status according to the rubric.

Note: If any category were to drift toward SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL, concrete changes would include expanding explicit articulation of the “living curriculum” in faculty materials, or adding more explicit statements about “parents as co-educators” in public pages, but such steps are already largely in evidence in OL SHA’s publicly shared materials.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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